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Salil Sahadevan

In the mid-19th century, an Austrian monk bred generations of pea plants in his monastery garden with meticulous care. He mapped their traits, recorded the results, and published them in an unknown journal. He went back to his regular teaching, and his work went unnoticed. Decades later, biologists revisited his paper and notes in the margins and found that his experiments revealed the basis of heredity. Once a forgotten footnote, the garden experiment became the seed of modern genetics, and Gregor Mendel its father.

Forgotten
A century later, British chemist Rosalind Franklin captured an X-ray image that revealed the double helix structure of DNA. Known as Photo 51, it was within the footnote of her lab logs and might have remained unseen until Watson and Crick allegedly used it to claim the breakthrough leading to the Nobel Prize, leaving Franklin in the margins for years. Sometimes, we look too late into the margins of knowledge. In the 14th century, Kerala mathematician Sangamagrama Madhava charted the infinite series for sine, cosine, and approximated pi, long before Newton or Leibniz. His work remained obscure until Charles M. Whish, an East India Company official, highlighted the Kerala School. Later, historian Ge-



Following a footnote

Breakthrough learning often hides in footnotes and margins. How can we train ourselves to value these overlooked learning spaces?

orge Gheverghese Joseph furthered this recognition. Recently, Malayalam professor Litty Chacko uncovered unpublished fragments of the works of Madhava after two decades of sifting through thousands of palm-leaf manuscripts. When I asked how, she replied, “From the margins, always from the margins.”

Compression at a cost
The main narratives miss what matters most. The surprise is in the margins and footnotes, where few look. This is more so, as we tend to shrink every communication into shorts, snippets and capsules. We live in the age of compression bias, where news is reduced to push alerts and books condensed into

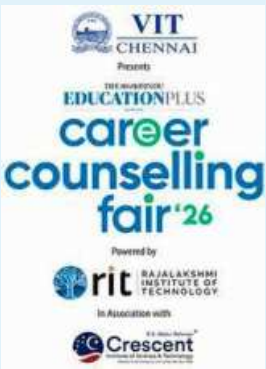
summaries. See the same logic in our conversations when we say “cut to the chase” or “give me the gist”. It is convenient and efficient, but comes at a cost. The margins, where novelty often begins, are erased in summarisation, causing what does not fit to disappear. By ignoring the peripheries, we risk recycling old ideas.

Why do these margins matter? They hold the pieces of knowledge that do not have a home as yet in the mainstream story. They hold contradictions, odd questions, and failed attempts as raw materials for new knowledge, making margins and footnotes intellectual commons free from the pressures of popularity and marketability.

Keeping them alive
So how do we keep the margins alive? Make spaces for incidental learning. You follow one idea and a note at the bottom opens a new door. The thrill of chasing a reference chain teaches a kind of thinking that uses the courage to wander. Serendipity thrives in those knowledge wanderings. If we do not do this, there is a personal loss. Students raised only on summaries and MCQs become efficient consumers but shallow explorers. In classrooms, it starts with design. Assign work that requires citations. Pick a Wikipedia page on a topic and follow a few linked pages in sequence, noting how each click bends the conversation in unexpected ways, turning a single fact into a series of discoveries. From a passage with rich footnotes, try tracing references back to their source to find surprising insights that did not make it into the main text. Do this with an AI-based citation network, even if that may lead nowhere. Explore connections in ancient texts and palm-leaves using Machine Learning and create spaces for open-ended research where the outcome is unknown. Note: Exciting rabbit holes often begin at the edges of the page, where the next chapter starts. Views expressed in this article are personal

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OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

I am preparing for competitive exams, but feel mentally exhausted. I used to be a topper, but I am struggling with consistency and motivation. Why is this happening. Kanagavalli

Dear Kanagavalli, This could be a mix of much that you are feeling right now: performance anxiety, others' expectations of you (living up to being a topper), your own identity crisis, peer pressure and just sheer cognitive burnout. Competitive exams do not guarantee success; they are a process in themselves, and often laborious. They are uncertain, hard, long, repetitive, and have long portions. So maybe there is some self-doubt creeping in as well: what if I fail and don't make it? Meet a therapist and claim your sense of calm, confidence, and study habits. Only preparation and performance are in your control. Nothing else! Reclaim your self-worth and prepare sincerely, honestly, and earnestly. If this exam is not meant to be, work on your Plan B and C. Something better is always in store! Do not limit yourself by feeling under-confident.

I graduated from Jammu University (distance education) in 2022 and live in a rural area near the international border. I am now preparing for the Civil Services exam. Sometimes, I feel demotivated because of my educational background and struggle with confidence and communication skills. Sehaj

Dear Sehaj, What you are feeling is

Prepare honestly

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

common and has nothing to do with your intelligence or potential. Civil Services officers are also selected from distance education, state universities, rural and remote regions, and first-generation learners. The exam rewards clarity of thought, consistency, resilience and ability to learn and apply. Your background is not a disadvantage but a strength because you understand grassroots realities, have probably seen governance gaps firsthand, and know what exclusion feels like. Why are you feeling demotivated? Do not compare yourself to English-medium toppers, coaching narratives, or social media success stories. Getting stuck in identity conflict and believing a narrative of isolation will only impact your confidence and communication further. Good communication is not a fluent English accent. It is about structured thinking, clarity, simplicity and honesty. Start reading the newspaper out loud. Summarise what you read in your own words, record yourself (audio), and you will hear improvement within a month. Use online discussions and peer groups to get help and motivate yourself.

I am a Class 11 Humanities student preparing for CLAT. I have good speaking skills, but I am nervous about public speaking and get easily influenced. I often feel tense about handling college life and dealing with manipulative people. How do I overcome these challenges? Sakshi

Dear Sakshi, It is normal to feel anxious and tense about college while still in school. You should only care about doing well, learning and enjoying the experiences in college, not about judging yourself and overthinking before anything happens. You are very young and impressionable, and it is easy to get influenced and swayed by others. So, identify your core values and use them as your guiding light when you form friendships and other associations. Trust your gut and do not sign up to anything on the spot because of persuasion and pressure. Work on the pros and cons of every decision and then get back to people and choices. This will help you make informed decisions and keep you safe. Consciously create distance from people who could be manipulative. You do not need to please anyone, especially if you feel confused or drained after interactions. You do not owe them any, so don't feel scared or overwhelmed. Be comfortable in your own skin and work on your self-esteem. Engage in a daily healthy routine that helps you stay grounded and balanced and convert nervous energy into structured expression.

My cousin is finishing B.Tech Computer Science from a tier-3 college and is concerned about poor placement prospects. He wants to work in a field that uses Python. How can he get a good job? Poojitha

Dear Poojitha, A tier-3 college does not block good careers in

technology any more. Python-based career options are in demand. He can look at entry roles as a Backend Engineer, Junior Software Developer or be a Data Analyst, Business Analyst, Automation/Python Scripting Engineer, QA Automation Engineer, or DevOps. Let him work and strengthen his core foundations in Python (loops, OOP, file handling), Data Structures and Algorithms (basic), SQL, Git + GitHub. These decide interview survival, not certificates. He needs to pick one track across Backend Developer, Django/Flask, Data Analyst, Pandas and SQL or Automation, Selenium and PyTest. Each has its own specifications. He must work on building three to four solid GitHub projects. Internships are more important than placements. He should actively apply to startups and for contract roles or remote internships across LinkedIn, Internshala, Wellfound (AngelList Talent), or GitHub issues (open source). To crack interviews, let him practice Python problems daily (LeetCode/HackerRank) and communicate with clarity to get the edge. **Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.** The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

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Swathi Priya D.

Fifteen years ago, Nilima (name changed) and her husband, both with 90% visual impairment, sold candies at a suburban station in Chennai to sustain their family and to save money to travel to her university in a neighbouring city, and collect her B.A. Tamil degree certificates. Nilima's aspiration was to pursue a Master's degree. Through philanthropic intervention, she realised this dream and even secured employment as a Tamil teacher at the primary level in an established private global school. Nilima's determination earned public recognition and awards, crystallising a powerful narrative that resilience holds potential for social approval and appreciation. Yet, does this narrative, the school's charitable action, and public recognition constitute sufficient systemic efforts toward disability inclusion?

Perennial question
By early this year, the school terminated her employment, citing her disability as incompatible with technological advancement of smart classrooms. Nilima's situation reveals intersectional discrimination: gender, class, disability, technology, ta-

lent and the neo-liberal logic of economic return all converge to produce a precarity, which was further masked by the glorification of her resilience. The philanthropic intervention collapsed, as it addressed only her symptoms: providing educational access, employment, and income. Moreover, what prevented a well-resourced school from embedding disability inclusion into its technological advancements? This brings up the perennial question: Is disability inclusion in educational spaces merely an add-on? This necessitates a return to understanding what disability inclusion encompasses across visible and invisible disabilities. Disability inclusion requires an interrelated understanding across levels of policy/practice and theoretical frameworks so that it can move beyond symptomatic redressal. In *Justice and Equality in Higher Education*, Lorella Terzi notes that disability inclusion developed fundamentally in opposition to the idea of special education itself. The opposition shows a historical progression from segregationist approaches that isolated students with disabilities in separate institutions to integrationist approaches that placed them in mainstream classrooms to contemporary in-

clusive education policies that aspire to make inclusion inherent to education itself rather than mere policy compliance. Terzi theorises this progression through Amartya Sen's capability approach, which places human heterogeneity central to justice and equality. Shashikala Srinivasan, in *Liberal Education and its Discontents*, acknowledges liberal education's contribution to *Bildung*, the German concept emphasising the cultivation of the whole self through education. Contemporary liberal arts institutions in India have operationalised this vision through interdisciplinary curricula and residential models, exemplifying inclusion in their curricular and pedagogical design. Saikat Majumdar, in *College: Pathways of Possibility*, uses Howard Gardner's Multiple Intelligence theory to envision a model of liberal arts beyond the conventional cognitive-intellectual domain to include linguistic, musical, spatial and other forms of intelligence.

Examples
This diversity of intelligence matters because, as Terzi argues, the dominance of cognitive-intellectual domain excludes students, particularly those with learning disabilities,

who adopt alternative ways of learning. Multidisciplinary liberal arts education, by fostering multiple forms of intelligence and ways of knowing, can become inclusive, moving beyond structural integration to genuine pedagogical transformation. Ashoka University's Office of Learning Support emphasises that liberal arts education must reflect diversity. Initiatives like the College Readiness Programme for incoming students with disabilities ensure they have continued access to material resources and opportunities that nurture their intelligence. One Young India Fellow with visual disability mentioned that she was offered “a kind of inclusion that feels inherent to this environment and not a conscious intervention.” Similarly, Jindal Global University's robust programmes, such as the Peer-Led Disability Inclusion Society and the Centre for Neurodivergent Studies, emphasise the mission. Through the Inclusive University Alliance, Ashoka collaborates with other institutions like Azim Premji University, Krea University and several IITs and IIMs to expand disability inclusion across more campuses. What these stories illuminate is something more fundamental; the idiosyncratic human creativity within each person, expressed through seeing, hearing, engaging and interpreting the world. Educational institutions either amplify this art, allowing it to enrich the social fabric or render it invisible. But what about non-elite institutions, where resources for such innovative learning environments are scarce? How do we include these spaces, where the vast majority of students study, in this conversation?

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